

WINDOW SHOPPING

It was the shade of blue which puzzled The Painter. An Orchid blue? Splattered around her iris like a firework? Or a deeper Azure? Tiled in like a stained glass window.

He touched the stylus to his screen and sketched in the former. Then he stood to look “Alice” in the eye. Pin-pricks of light in the crystalline biogel set the Orchid in her eyes. It went well with that pale moonbeam skin he’d made. He returned his stylus to the screen, just to try the Azure eyes. He had time, afterall, for perfection.

Then,

A jingle rang through the store.

The Painter finished her other eye before he looked up.

A mother and daughter. Browsing the product. The Mother walked to the counter as the daughter continued to circle. Aimless.

“Do you do modifications?”

“Oh yes, all the time.”

Mother signalled the Daughter and she joined her at the counter. Six fingers on each hand.

“I think it’s cute, but she complains,” the Mother explained.

The painter ducked under the counter as she spoke and hooked his tablet to a box which he placed on the counter.

“Not uncommon at all,” he said. “It’s one hand at a time. Won’t hurt a bit.”

Six fingers entered the gel, visible through the glass and on the Painter’s screen.

He flicked one tab over, where yellow lines showed her nerves. Tapped the eraser icon with his stylus. Then traced away those lines in that sixth digit. It was one tab over for the flesh. A few strokes more and that was gone too.

Mother and Daughter watched as the sixth digit dissolved in the biogel. The flesh would be pumped to vats in the back. More Paint for the Painter.

When the process was mirrored, The Painter tapped a number on the register and turned the screen towards the Mother.

If she winced at the number, he didn’t notice. She still paid.

The Painter was sculpting Alice’s thin crescent smile, rose pink, when the bell chimed again.

This time a man wandered the room. So The Painter kept painting.

“Do you have this one in Aztec?” asked the man.

“No,” lied the Painter.

“... is this one an athlete?”

The Painter leaned over the counter to get a better look at the product. The tag read “Lilly” .

“That one’s another mathematician. Their quota’s a bit higher this quarter.”

The Man looked her up and down one more time.

“Well, I’ll talk to my wife about her,” He said.

“I’m sure you will,” The Painter said under his breath, so only Alice could hear.

When the studio closed for the night, the Painter looked up at his art. All frozen in perfection. So many could look, but so few could see. He pulled a curtain over the glass.

The Painter hated his work. He hated Window Shoppers. But there was nothing else for him.

He was a Painter. And it was all he was Painted to be.